6

It is perhaps not surprising that students preferred outdoor pursuits to classes. ‘There was no great striving upwards,’ Erich said, remembering his German language skills were weak but arithmetic above average.7 His uncle, Peter Weidenhof, encouraged him to try harder in German, saying that in politics, a good command of the language was essential. The story has often been told, in slightly differing versions, about how his parents made a successful request for him to be exempt from religious instruction, but as Honecker proudly asserted, that did not mean he was left without knowledge in that sphere, ‘whether the Bible, the Old and New Testaments or the problems of the philosophy of life’. He certainly never attended church when Katharina, his blond, blue-eyed sister, died of tuberculosis – a deadly condition stalking areas plagued by malnutrition and poverty. Looking back, he rather touchingly recounted how she had been ‘especially good’ at taking care of the family. ‘She was the eldest, besides that, she was a lovely girl. My parents were anxious to do everything for her, so because of her illness, she was given as little as possible to do. Of course, her death meant a drastic alteration in our family.’ Given the fear of contagion, Erich was briefly packed off to the safety of the countryside to avoid contact with Katharina as she slowly withered away.

To the outsider, Wiebelskirchen and the grasslands around Neunkirchen can appear bleak and a little uninviting. But this small corner of Europe left a powerful mark on Erich Honecker’s childhood. By the age of 14, he had joined the KJVD, the Young Communist League of Germany and was stomping around the region handing out propaganda. With the approach of manhood he avoided clambering down mine shafts, choosing instead to work on a farmstead in Neudorf with a smallholder named Wilhelm Streich, who along with his wife, daughters and elderly father, became as good as family.

He discovered an interest in agriculture and proved good at his job of milking cows, feeding cattle and chopping firewood. ‘The farmer,’ he pointed out, ‘had a bad hand and could only carry out the sowing, so the whole tilling of the field was done by the labourer and me, and later by me